PRELUDE XXIV

THE direction *Andante* is Bach's own, and should be taken in its literal meaning, " at a walking pace "—a gentle four in the bar. The accumulation of richer detail in the last five bars indicates a slight broadening of the *tempo* advisable for the rest of the movement; the general *tempo* should, therefore, neither drag nor necessitate anything surprising in this broadening. The bass should be *legato* and full of vocal melody, but on no account broken up into phrases, not even where it abruptly changes its octave, as in bar 22. The imitative duet played by the right hand should aim at the effect of two flutes; the part that leads the imitations should be fuller than the answering part.

This principle will produce frequent changes in the balance of tone. Thus, in bars 1-3, the lower part leads, and if the upper part entered with more than a mere echo-tone it would blend in a very disagreeable effect of consecutive fifths with the bass. But from bar 4 onwards the upper part leads; and in the close sequence beginning at bar 8 the parts are equal. At bar 12, again, the lower part definitely leads, until from the middle of bar 14 the parts leave imitation and proceed freely to a close. On the clavichord all manner of delicate light and shade was possible in such music. A *forte* was inconceivable, and any approach to it in this Prelude sounds detestable on the pianoforte. All suspended notes must be heard to be singing at the moment of suspension. This is possible only when the tone is not forced. The two places where the quaver movement of the bass stops (bars 16-17, and, still more, bars 42-43) require a deeper tone. The chromatic scale in bars 43-44 also marks a climax.

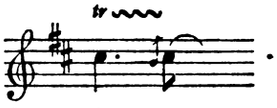
Mark the beginnings of new phrases in the right hand in the middle of bars 7, 27, 29, 32 (lower part) and 42, and at the beginning of bar 12.

FUGUE XXIV

THE direction *Largo* is Bach's own.

I. THEMES.—The Subject and Countersubject, as in bars 4-6. The first semiquaver figure of the Countersubject is treated separately by inversion in bars 9 and 13, and is also prominent in Episodes 5 and 6 (bars 34-37 and 41-43). The five crotchets of descending scale require, wherever they occur, a sustained *cantabile* tone; as is always the case where Bach uses a simple counterpoint in long notes that provide the chief cause of discords and their resolution. (Watch especially for the cases where these five crotchets are disguised by delaying the first, so that it becomes only a quaver, or has to be omitted—*e.g.*, the alto in bar 45; or, on the other hand, where it is anticipated, and so becomes a minim.) The final semiquaver figure of the Countersubject (bar 6) asserts itself as the most important of the accessory figures and, next to the five crotchets, produces most of the harmonic subtleties in the Fugue.

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The slurs given by Bach in the first three entries of the Subject should, of course, be understood to be applied wherever it occurs. The final shake, given in all the autographs only in the first statement, may also (as always in such contexts) be played wherever it does not cause difficulty or confusion. Where convenient, it should end with the usual turn. Where the minim is tied to something else (as in bar 15), the shake (if played) may be stopped on the last quaver, with or without a grace-note, thus:  . In some cases the shake may conveniently be represented by ~~ (as in bar 50).

II. Episodic Themes.—Episode 1, an imitative chain of suspensions, is in bars 7-8, and is alluded to in bars 24-25 and, less prominently, in bars 37 and 52.

The most important Episode is the third (bars 17-20). It introduces a new imitative figure, which is reproduced in bars 26-29, and, after a long interval, in the course of the ninth and last Episode (bars 65-68). This figure is best treated as a most delicate *pianissimo* in all three cases. Nothing else brings out so well the harmonic value of the suspended discords; nor is it otherwise possible to do justice to one of the most subtle and dramatic inspirations in all Bach's Fugues, the ghost-like appearance of the first three notes of the Subject, abruptly cut short, twice (in the alto in bar 19, the tenor having crossed above it, and in the tenor in bar 28), followed in each case by the entry of the whole Subject in the same voice and position two bars later. Throughout the Episode the bass should be the faintest of all, since it cannot fail to be heard, while the suspensions are in danger of failing.

Episode 5 (bars 34-37) is concerned with the first bar of the Subject and the first semiquaver figure of the Countersubject. It is reproduced in Episode 6 (bars 41-43). In a big Fugue on a long Subject it is important that such episodic uses of the first bar alone should not be given with the same emphasis as the entry of the whole Subject. If they lead up to that event as a climax, well and good, but they must not forestall it. It is, in Fugues of this type, an important event, and (especially in a *tempo* marked by Bach himself as *Largo*) demands from the pianoforte-player the most careful economy of tone. Bars 44 and 70 are, then, notable for entries of the whole Subject by way of a climax, which must not be spoiled by premature emphasis in the previous bars. Detached chords and rests of the type seen in bar 73 almost always indicate in Bach that he has reached his final climax.

In three places it has been necessary to provide an alternative reading. The first place is in bar 13, where we must not undertake to make up Bach's mind for him when he took extraordinary pains without making a final decision. He attached great importance to the rules of "Tonal Fugue," and in bar 4 he changed the fifth note of his Answer from C♯ to B, in order to obey those rules. This meant substituting bold and subtle two-part harmony for what was at first a simple enough progression; but the result is characteristic and convincing. With the entry of the fourth part (soprano), however, this tonal answer is almost impossible to harmonise, and the autographs leave it doubtful whether Bach was really satisfied with his alteration there. Even according to scholastic rule it is no longer so necessary to make a strictly tonal answer when the fourth voice appears, and the easier reading is certainly also authentic. We therefore give it as the text, without venturing to suppress Bach's own alteration.

The other two places concern a distortion of an important figure (bars 36 and 63) necessitated for Bach only by the fact that his clavichord could not go beyond C♮.